popular with the Conservative party. His appearance in front of the House of Commons in July 1920 in which he denounced the action of General Dyer in the Amritsar Massacre had demonstrated just this.[77] Montagu did not appear to be a good debater, nor was he adept at winning people over to his point of view (a skill particularly crucial in a coalition government). As one historian has put it, the secretary of state's 'hypersensitive temperament...was ill-suited to his political role'.[78] His joint authorship of the Indian reforms of 1919 also meant that 'An idea was prevalent that...he was an exponent of an anti-British policy in India'.[79] As trouble developed in India during this period, much of the good-will felt by Britain towards the Indian people following the war began to dissipate. As Montagu explained to Reading in February 1922:

The fact of the matter is, Rufus, that people here are fed up with India, and it is all I can do to keep my colleagues steady on the accepted policy, let alone new instalments of it. The Indians are so unreasonable, so slow to compromise, so raw in their resentments, and the insults to the Prince of Wales have made fierce feeling in this country.[80]

As well as a growing backlash against the Montagu-Chelmsford reforms, there was also a belief among some that by his constant emphasis of the Caliphate issue, Montagu had lent that movement a level of legitimacy and publicity.[81] Fairly or unfairly, the verdict was in on Montagu's tenure as secretary of state for India.[82]

Unfortunately for him, Montagu's actions after his resignation only served to further his unpopularity. Together with his criticisms of Lloyd George, the ex-secretary of state could not help attacking Curzon for his alleged role in the affair. According to Montagu, Curzon had known about the publication of the viceroy's telegram at a Cabinet meeting the following day, and had said nothing: 'But what did Lord Curzon do? He maintained silence in the Cabinet and contented himself that evening with writing to me one of those plaintive, hectoring, bullying, complaining letters which